THE DAM(N) PROJECT: *Jobat Calling*

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ABSTRACT

Jobat Calling is a live and interactive audiovisual installation which connects Australian and Indian communities around a common concern: water security. It presents the lives of remote communities in the Narmada Valley, displaced by large-scale dam development securing hydropower for Indian cities. It presents the lives of remote communities in the Narmada Valley, displaced by large-scale dams developed to create power for Indian cities. The central idea within DAM(N) is the nature and mythology of water, its creative/destructive powers and our constant obsession to control it in the event of imminent scarcity. This presentation will showcase the long-term contribution of creative industries can make to communities in struggle.

1. BACKGROUND

The construction of large dams on the River Narmada in India and its impact on millions of people living in the river valley has become one of the most important social issues in contemporary India. The Narmada Dams Project is the biggest of its kind in the world and whilst proponents of the dams believe it will provide water security to 30 million people and provide 1.45 GW of power, the dams will internally displace up to half a million people. Global coalitions of environmental and human rights activist groups condemn the project for several reasons including corrupt and iniquitous cost benefit analyses and destruction of arable land [1,2]. Over the past 25 years, the controversy has come to symbolise the struggle for a just and equitable society in India.

2. OUR STORY

The project follows the creative team (Shakthi Sivanathan, Jehan Kanga, Leah Barclay, Meghna Nambiar, and Sylvester Mardi) through their journey into the heart of India collecting stories from affected towns. Interviews were also collected in central North-West India in the Narmada Valley from adivasi protesters and displaced farmers in the affected villages of Badwani, Jobat and Badal. In Badwani and Jobat, we interviewed key indigenous protesters such as Bhagirath Dhangar (Badwani Narmada Bachao Andolan) and Shrikanth (Jobat NBA). In Jobat, we collected stories from over 20 displaced groups who had gathered at a satyagraha (non-violent protest). They told their stories whilst preparing dinners and lunches, and singing tribal and solidarity songs.

Embedding ourselves within both the satyagraha and within remote affected communities was a vital part of capturing a complete story across the widely varied landscape. In Badwani we also interviewed Dayal Solanki, a young adivasi whose story became the common thread for our journey. He became our guide through to the extremely remote village of Badal, accessible only by fishing boat from a makeshift wharf one hour from the nearest town. The region, which is now almost completely submerged under reservoir, was formerly one of the most agriculturally productive regions in India. We stayed in Dayal's home perched on the arid crest of a mountain, and stayed with his family recording their stories of displacement and the hope they placed in their children.



Figure 1. Dayal's younger brothers Dalsingh and Kamish on the arid banks of the now submerged village of Badal.

We captured the stories and music of his whole family undertaking some digital workshops with the children to involve them in the story telling process.

Upon returning to Jobat, Meghna and Sylvester undertook dance workshops with children at a Jivanshala (NGO sponsored school), and expressed their experiences of the Narmada Valley through various site specific dance routines in Badal and on Jobat Dam. Shakthi, Leah and Jehan undertook further digital workshops at the Jobat Jivanshala.



Figure 2. A student at the Jivanshala learning about capturing sound during a digital media workshop in Jobat.

We enabled the children to collect images, video and sound to tell their story from their perspective. The incorporation of these capacity building workshops within the film will showcase the long-term contribution of creative industries can make to communities in struggle.

3. JOBAT CALLING

The presented audiovisual installation is a 20 minute is an interactive mixed media work. It is designed to work as a standalone installation or in conjunction with a choreographed dance by a member of the Attakkalari repertory. The installation also involves a solo voice interacting with the soundscape.

The installation is the first major creative outcome from a Project that will also yield a one hour mixed media dance performance, an immersive exhibition of photographs, soundscapes and short films, and finally a documentary covering the rapidly changing political landscapes around water security in India in the Narmada and in Australia in the Murray Darling as well as the creative process which becomes the lens through which this landscape unfolds.

We would like to think The DAM(IN) Project will become a model for artistic development for young artists, a model for complex collaborations between more than two major performing arts organizations which all have significant creative input, and a model for the development of new opportunities for both artists and performing arts organisations to find new audiences.



Figure 2. Co-choreographers Meghna Nambiar and Sylvester Mardi on top of Jobat Dam, December 2012.

4. REFERENCES

[1] Drèze, J., Samson, M. Singh, S. *Dam and the nation: displacement and resettlement in the Narmada Valley*. 1997 New Delhi, Oxford University Press

[2] Sen, A. "The Discipline of Cost Benefit Analysis" *Journal of Legal Studies* 2000, 29(S2), pp931-952.